ONE-NOTE OSTINATO METHOD



A CREATIVE GUIDE TO WRITING CHORD PROGRESSIONS

JAZZ LAB

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INTRO

Welcome to **The One-Note Ostinato Method** — a fresh, creative approach to composing music that blends simplicity with sophistication. Inspired by the styles of artists like Radiohead, Brad Mehldau, and Coldplay, this method teaches you how to build entire chord progressions from a single note. Whether you're a beginner or an experienced musician, this guide will help you unlock new ways to think about harmony, often finding surprising and "magical" chord progression in an intuitive and easy way.

The more knowledge and theory background you have, the more daring your experiments you can be; however, more complexity doesn't necessarily translate into better composition. True mastery resides in the simple ways to create sophistication.

Instead of talking about terms like "modal interchange", "upper structures", "secondary dominants", we will take a more hands-on approach jumping straight to the exercise. Theory comes second; making music comes first - always.

THE CONCEPT



At the heart of this method lies one simple idea: **build your composition around a single note,** using a simple ostinato.

An **ostinato** is a repeating rhythmic or melodic pattern that runs through a piece. In this approach, that repeated note becomes the anchor — the thread that ties your chords together.

Example:

Let's pick the note **A** (higher pitches sound better)
Now, create a repeating rhythmic pattern for it. There are endless options according to your level of familiarity and experience:

Here are some super simple ones in 4/4:





If you are into odd meters, try something in 5/8 or 7/8





If you like polyrrhythms, maybe try one with dotted note values:



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If this is your first experiment, I recommend using the simplest ostinatos. Our work will be mostly in the real of harmony, so you don't wanna be wasting too much of your buffering power on rhythms and coordination.

Once you choose your ostinato, the next step is to create a huge list of all possible chords that may include the note **A.**



TIER 1
FOUNDATION CHORDS

Start simple. Choose the simplest chords that contain the note **A** (major or minor triads only). These are your foundational chords — the ones that will give your progression stability and clarity.

A Am D Dm F F#m

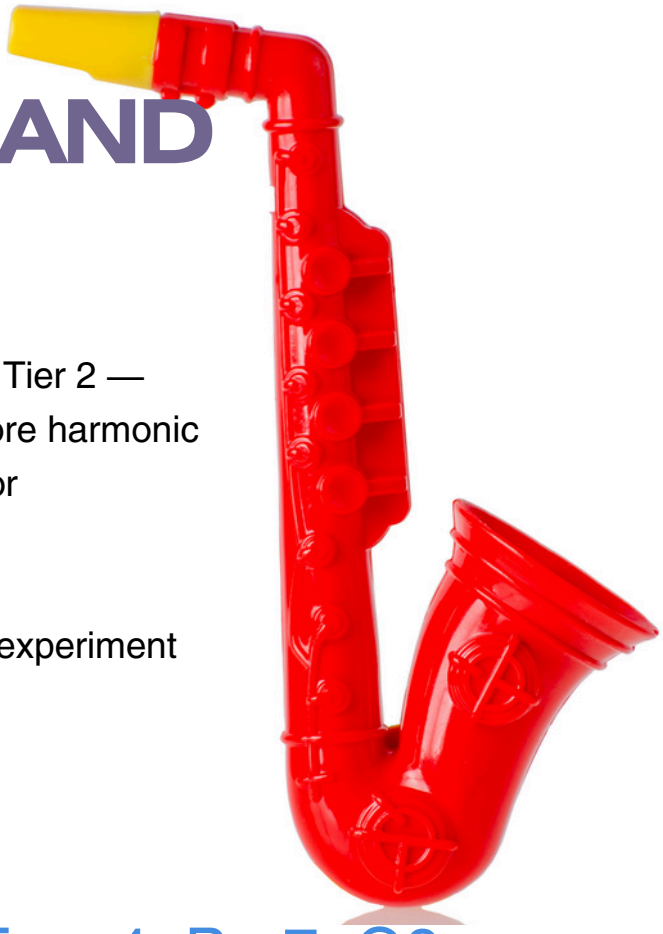
The six chords above are your foundational chords. You may record your ostinato on a voice memo or a loop pedal or a DAW and play it back while you experiment playing these chords on the background. Try combining four of these chords into a repeated progression. For instance:

F#m Dm Am F

Even with just four chords, you'll notice how rich and expressive the sound can be. Simplicity often leads to the most beautiful results.

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TIER 2
ADDING COLOR AND COMPLEXITY



Once you're comfortable with Tier 1, move to Tier 2 — chords that still include the note A but add more harmonic color. These might include sevenths, ninths, or suspended chords.

This list can be extense, so take your time to experiment and think about different options.

Here are some Examples:

B7 Bbmaj7 Gm9 Cm6 Esus4 Bm7 G9

When using Tier 2 chords, balance is key. Too many complex chords can make your progression lose its grounding. Try mixing one chord of Tier 2 with three chords of Tier 1 for the best effect.

Example progression:

A F Bbmaj7 D

This blend of simple and complex chords creates a progression that feels both grounded and sophisticated.

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TIER 3
THE EXPERIMENTAL ZONE



Now it's time to explore. Tier 3 is where you can go wild — experiment with jazz chords, altered harmonies, polychords, and unexpected voicings. The sky is the limit; the wider your harmonic options, the more chords you will come up with. Eventually you will conclude that basically every chord can include the note **A** depending on how well you orchestrate it (voicing).

Here are just a few examples.

Eb7(#11) Ab13(b9) C#maj7(#5) Csus13

These chords can sound unusual or "bizarre," but they add personality and tension when used sparingly. Using too many of these in a progression may make your composition sound like a parody of complex jazz reharmonizations. Use them with parsimony!

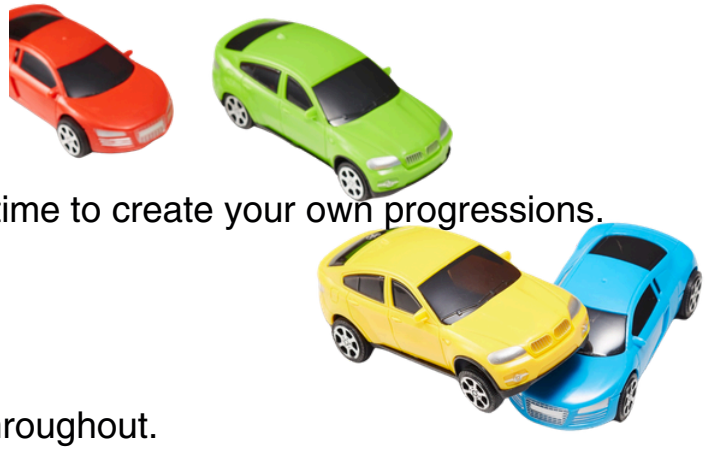
Example progression:

F# minor → A minor → Gmaj9 → Ab7(b9)

Notice how the progression feels adventurous but still connected through the note A. We are intuitively using the anchor note as a tool for excellent voice-leading!

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BUILDING YOUR OWN PROGRESSIONS



Now that you understand the three tiers, it's time to create your own progressions.

Here's a step-by-step process:

1. Pick your note (e.g., A).
2. Create an ostinato rhythm that repeats throughout.
3. Choose four chords — mostly from Tier 1, with one or two from Tier 2 or 3.
4. Experiment with different combinations.
5. Listen and refine.

Example progression:
A → D minor → Esus → A minor → F → D → Bbmaj7 → Gsus
This progression blends simplicity, color, and surprise — the essence of the one-note ostinato method.

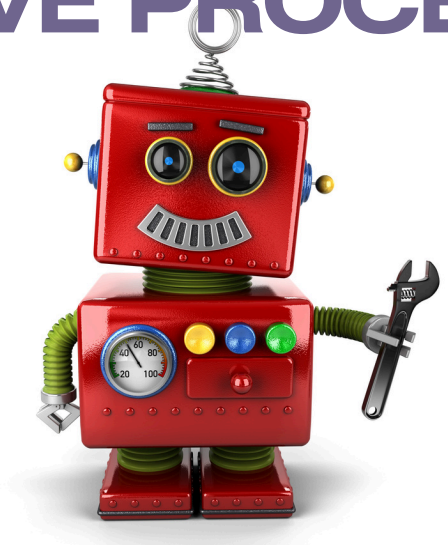
I recommend writing 20 different four chord progressions, you can even do it randomly without thinking too much. Then try all of them and mark the ones that sound powerful/intriguing/magical.

Play the progressions while playing the ostinato (remember, you can program the ostinato on a DAW, loop pedal, or even ask a friend to play it while you experiment.

Shorter progressions normally sound more powerful, memorable. Aaron Park's "Nemesis", for example, has a great four chord progression over a one note ostinato.

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CREATIVE PROCESS TIPS



Writing music is about exploration, not perfection. Don’t expect your first progression to be your best. Try writing 20 or more different combinations. Out of those, you might find two or three that truly resonate. That’s the process — experimentation, discovery, and refinement.

Remember: **complexity doesn’t equal quality.** The most moving music often comes from simple ideas developed with care and intention.

TRY THIS:

- Write a B part for your tune in which your ostinato note changes! What if your original A now becomes Bb? This unveils a whole new harmonic universe with new tiers and options. (Listen to Ehud Ettun's "Transparency", and see if you can spot the modulation)

- Try a 2-note ostinato, picking 2 initial pitches. You will have less options for chords, but the effect can be very powerful.

- Try writing words or other melodies over the ostinato and chords. Listen to Chopin's Prelude No. 15 and how he creates melodies in both the low and high registers surrounding a one note ostinato.

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